an iron tube and bamboo rod, packed with combustible material which was lit and then directed by hand and launched primarily at horses and elephants) and 12,000 boats were available at Agra in full preparedness.' Akbar also urged Munim Khan to be extremely vigilant and to prevent dereliction of duty amongst the soldiers. Munim Khan himself was instructed to pay special attention to the royal elephants, and to supervise their diets personally. The Padshah even listed the names of the elephants being sent to Munim Khan—these included Dodi, also known as Mal Jamal Bahadur Shahi, who was the Padshah's personal elephant.

Akbar's ability to react instantly to events happening in the different corners of the empire even as he remained constantly on the move, depended, as we have seen, on an extensive system of couriers and informants who relayed information to the Padshah. Qandahari has described this extremely efficient system:

> He [Akbar] is such an expert in espionage that he keeps four thousand* foot-runners, who in Hindi are called Meurah. They are on His Majesty's service day and night so that news and reports reach regularly everyday from all sides of the world. This class of men run as fast as lions, so that within ten days news comes from Bengal, which is at a distance of seven hundred karohs (kos) from Agra. His Majesty gets all information of good or bad and profit or loss.

Akbar then turned his attention to the town of Surat where, it was learnt, the inconstant Ibrahim Sultan Mirza was strengthening the defences of the city. Akbar besieged Surat in January 1573 and it was here, during the siege, that he met the Portuguese for the first time. The meeting with the Portuguese envoy, Antonio de Cabral, was conducted with great bonhomie and Akbar questioned the Portuguese closely 'about the wonders of Portugal and the manners and customs of Europe'. The Padshah was already watching the distant horizons beyond the heaving ocean to learn what the wide world had to offer. Akbar was delighted with gifts of Portuguese cloaks and hats and, according to Qandahari, there were also cartloads of Portuguese wine, whose 'scent turned the lions of skies dead-drunk'. But an important concession was made by the Portuguese when they issued passes to members of Akbar's family to go on pilgrimage to Mecca. For it was not only trade that Surat was vital for, it was also the 'Gateway to Mecca', so